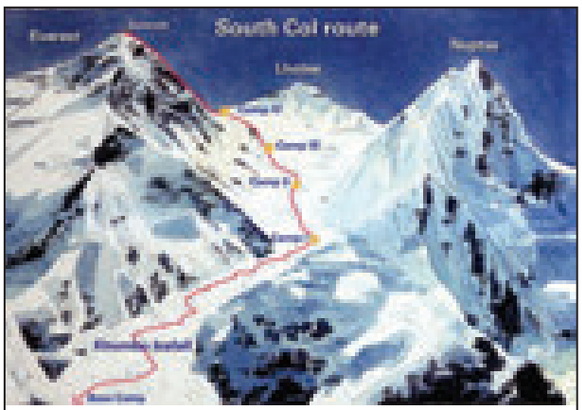
3. At 6.30 a.m. we crawled out of that tent into the snow, hoisted our 30 **lb**. of oxygen gear on to our backs, connected up our masks and turned on the valves to bring life-giving oxygen into our lungs. A few good deep breaths and we were ready to go. Still a little worried about my cold feet, I asked Tenzing to move off.

4. Tenzing kicked steps in a long **traverse** back towards the ridge, and we reached its crest where it forms a great snow bump at about 28000 feet. From here the ridge narrowed to a knife-edge and, as my feet were now warm, I took over the lead.



Col depression in a mountain chain; a pass

5. The soft snow made a route on top of the ridge both difficult and dangerous, which sometimes held my weight but often gave way suddenly. After several hundred feet, we came to a tiny hollow, and found there the two oxygen bottles left on the earlier attempt by Evans and Bourdillon. I scraped the ice off the gauges and was relieved to find that they still contained several hundred litres of oxygen – enough to get us down to the South Col if used sparingly.

6. I continued making the trail on up the ridge, leading up for the last 400 feet to the southern summit. The snow on this face was dangerous, but we persisted in our efforts to beat a trail up it.

7. We made frequent changes of lead. As I was stamping a trail in the deep snow, a section around me gave way and I slipped back through three or four of my steps. I discussed with Tenzing the advisability of going on, and he, although admitting that he felt unhappy about the snow conditions, and finished with his familiar phrase "Just as you wish".

8. I decided to go on; and we finally reached firmer snow higher up, and then chipped steps up the last steep slopes and cramponed on to the South Peak. It was now 9 a.m.

9. We cut a seat for ourselves just below the South Summit and removed our oxygen apparatus. As our first partly-full bottle of oxygen was now exhausted, we had only one full bottle left. Our apparatus was now much lighter, weighing just over 20 lb., and as I cut steps down off the South Summit I felt a sense of freedom and well - being.

10. As my ice-axe bit into the first steep slope of the ridge, my high hopes were realized. The snow was crystalline and firm. Two or three blows of the ice - axe produced a step large enough even for our over-sized High Altitude boots, and a firm thrust of the ice-axe would sink it half-way up the shaft, giving a solid and comfortable belay.

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